Class 10 SST - Chapter 13: Power Sharing

🌟 Introduction to the Chapter

With this chapter, we resume the tour of democracy that started last year. We note that in a democracy, all power does not normally rest with only one organ of the government. An intelligent sharing of power among legislature, executive, and judiciary is crucial.

📌 Case Studies: Belgium and Sri Lanka

Belgium (A Story of Accommodation)

Belgium is a small country in Europe with a very complex ethnic composition.

- **Population:** 59% live in the Flemish region and speak Dutch. 40% live in the Wallonia region and speak French. 1% speak German.
- **Capital (Brussels):** However, in the capital Brussels, 80% speak French, while 20% are Dutch-speaking.
- **The Solution:** Between 1970 and 1993, the Belgian leaders amended their constitution four times so as to work out an arrangement that would enable everyone to live together within the same country peacefully. They created equal representation in the central government and a unique "Community Government."

Sri Lanka (A Story of Majoritarianism)

Sri Lanka is an island nation.

- **Population:** Sinhalese speakers (74%) and Tamil speakers (18%).

- **The Problem:** The democratically elected government adopted a series of Majoritarian measures to establish Sinhala supremacy (like making Sinhala the only official language).
- **The Result:** This alienation led to the Sri Lankan Tamils demanding an independent Tamil Eelam, resulting in a devastating civil war.

⚡ Forms of Power Sharing

In modern democracies, power sharing arrangements can take many forms:

1. **Horizontal Distribution of Power:** Power is shared among different organs of government, such as the legislature, executive, and judiciary. This allows for a system of checks and balances.
2. **Vertical Distribution of Power:** Power is shared among governments at different levels (central, state, and local governments).
3. **Power Sharing Among Different Social Groups:** Power may also be shared among different religious and linguistic groups (e.g., Community government in Belgium).
4. **Power Sharing Among Political Parties and Pressure Groups:** This ensures that power does not remain in one hand. In the long run, power is shared among different political parties that represent different ideologies and social groups.

❌ Common Mistakes to Avoid

> [!WARNING]
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> 1. **Majoritarianism:** Do not define it just as "majority rule." It is the belief that the majority community should be able to rule a country in whichever way it wants, by disregarding the true wishes and needs of the minority.
> 2. **Belgium Capital:** Brussels has a totally inverse linguistic makeup compared to the rest of the country. Do not mix up the Flemish and Walloon percentages!

📝 Quick Revision

Why Power Sharing is Desirable?

There are two sets of reasons:

1. **Prudential Reasons:** Power sharing helps to successfully reduce the possibility of conflict between social groups. It is a good way to ensure the absolute stability of political order.
2. **Moral Reasons:** Power sharing is the very spirit of democracy. A democratic rule involves seamlessly sharing power with those affected by its exercise. People have a right to be consulted on how they are to legitimately be governed.